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WILLIAM WHYTE, OPEN SPACE, AND ENVIRONMENTAL ACTIVISM

ADAM W. ROME

ABSTRACT. In the late 1950s and early 1960s a variety of Americans began to protest the loss of open space to suburban sprawl. The critics of sprawl—William Whyte, most notably—argued that open space had great aesthetic, social, and ecological value. To preserve open space, activists lobbied for the acquisition of public land and touted land-saving forms of development. Although both efforts brought important successes, both proved inadequate. Even so, the open-space debate had enduring consequences: It shaped later efforts to force builders to meet new environmental obligations, and it played a key role in the evolution of the environmental movement. *Keywords:* *environmentalism, suburbs, urban planning.*

“Take a last look,” William Whyte told the readers of *Life* in 1959. “Some summer’s morning drive past the golf club on the edge of town, turn off onto a back road and go for a short trip through the open countryside. Look well at the meadows, the wooded draws, the stands of pine, the creeks and streams, and fix them in your memory. If the American standard of living goes up another notch, this is about the last chance you will have” (1959c, 88).

Why? What was the problem? “Go back toward the city five or 10 miles,” Whyte wrote.

Here, in what was pleasant countryside only a year ago, is a sight of what is to come. No more sweep of green—across the hills are splattered scores of random subdivisions, each laid out in the same dreary asphalt curves. Gone are the streams, brooks, woods and forests that the subdivisions’ signs talked about. The streams are largely buried in concrete culverts. Where one flows briefly through a patch of weeds and tin cans it is fetid with the ooze of septic tanks. A row of stumps marks the place where sycamores used to shade the road and if a stand of maple or walnut still exists the men with power saws will soon be at it. Here and there a farm remains, but the “For Sale” signs are up and now even the golf course is to be chopped into lots. (1959c, 88–89)

The lament was common. In the years after World War II, as the nation’s builders turned acre after acre into suburban subdivisions, a large number of Americans became concerned about the transformation of the landscape. What could be done to stop the destruction of the countryside? By the end of the 1950s, the question was at the heart of a new kind of conservation effort—a multifaceted campaign to save the nation’s open space. Although scholars so far have written little about the subject, the campaign to save open space had profound consequences. It was the first broad attempt to deal with some of the problems caused by the postwar pattern of development, and it shaped later efforts to force builders to meet new environmental obliga-

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tions. In a number of ways, the effort to preserve open space was a critical stage in the evolution of the modern environmental movement.¹

The open-space issue was rooted in the profound transformation of the building industry during and after World War II. For the first time, the industry was dominated by large builders using mass-production techniques to transform tracts of hundreds or thousands of acres into new neighborhoods. The industry's output reached unprecedented levels: In the 1950s, builders put up more than 15 million homes, mostly at the edges of the nation's cities. For a number of reasons, the average size of residential lots also rose. The metropolitan area of the nation, as a result, grew by leaps and bounds. Throughout the 1950s, the nation's cities and suburbs took a million more acres every year—a territory larger than Rhode Island (Rome 1996).

Just as significantly, the face of development changed. Before 1945, builders often had to bypass large wetlands and steep slopes. But with the earth-moving machinery developed during the war, and with the new economies of large-scale construction, postwar builders could consider almost any kind of land. Indeed, as land costs skyrocketed in the 1950s, the trade publications of the building industry were full of exhortations to investigate lands once considered unbuildable. "Need Land?" the headline of one article asked. "Then Take a Look at Marshland." Another told "How to Hit Paydirt on a Hillside." Builders avidly took the advice. From the mid-1950s to the mid-1970s, almost a million acres of marshes, swamps, bogs, and coastal estuaries were destroyed by urban development. Builders even began to subdivide wetlands the size of the Florida Everglades. Although no one gathered nationwide statistics on hillside development, there is no doubt that construction tore into the hills in many parts of the nation after 1945. One of the most popular houses of the 1950s—the split level—was designed in part to suit lots on steeply sloped ground. Overall, then, fewer spaces were left open in the new metropolitan landscape because of unsuitable terrain (Rome 1996).

In laying out neighborhoods, moreover, builders rarely provided public green space. In some cases they argued that families with yards would not need parks. In other cases they offered no explanation or justification—they simply wanted to maximize the number of lots per tract. Either way, the layout of new subdivisions marked a significant departure from older neighborhoods with single-family homes. In the New York Metropolitan Area, for example, the postwar tracts had just one-tenth as much park acreage as had the neighborhoods established in the first four decades of the twentieth century—2.7 out of every 100 acres, instead of 27. For a while, the undeveloped land at the edge of a tract might serve as a kind of park. But as development spread, as nearby woods and streams disappeared, the absence of permanent open space became more noticeable (Rome 1996).

By the time Whyte published his call for action in *Life*, a diverse group of people had voiced concerns about the loss of open space. In the professions directly concerned with the shape of the metropolis—architecture and urban planning—the costs of sprawl were a topic of intense interest by the mid-1950s. In addition to worrying about the difficulty of providing adequate streets, sanitary systems, and schools

in new communities, the professional critics of sprawl were given to complaining about the lack of open space. The subject soon attracted the attention of civic clubs and foundations, especially in New York and California. The effort to preserve open space included government officials, conservationists, and advocates of parks and playgrounds. In a number of communities, the advance of development led to the formation of grassroots groups, often led by women, to "save our trees" or "stop the rape of the valley" (Whyte 1959c, 90). Farmers sometimes joined the protests.

The open-space activists made three kinds of arguments. In the words of the time, one was a conservation argument. Another argument, essentially aesthetic, focused on amenity. The third dealt with outdoor recreation. Although many advocates of open space sought to be comprehensive, the three lines of argument had different roots and could appeal to different sorts of people (Higbee 1960; RPA 1960; Wingo 1963; Strong 1965; Zisman 1965; Williams 1969; Little and Mitchell 1971).

Because the archetypical postwar subdivision was built on farmland, a number of open-space advocates argued that the nation was risking the loss of a vital productive resource (Jarrett 1958; Owen 1959; Hubbard 1960; Dasmann 1965; Degnan 1965). The acreage lost was only a small fraction of the nation's total agricultural land base, yet doubts persisted about the wisdom of building houses on prime farmland. For the doubters, the issue was a matter of culture, not just agricultural production. In the 1950s more than 10 million people left farms, and the outcry against the suburbanization of the countryside was partly a way to express anxiety about the social consequences of a profound demographic change: If the city continued to swallow up the country, would Americans forget the agrarian virtues that had made the nation great? Although that question was seldom raised directly, advocates of open space argued that conservation of prime agricultural lands in fast-growing areas would ensure that urban and suburban people retained "a sense of rural life" (Herring 1961, 12).

By 1960 a number of civil engineers and conservation officials were arguing that open space had a functional value as a check against flooding (U.S. Congress, Senate 1961; Levine 1964; Strong 1965). Floodplains and wetlands both were natural sponges, soaking up runoff after storms, and communities could reduce the need for expensive public works by preserving both types of land as open space. Woodlands served a similar function; by slowing runoff, trees allowed more water to soak into the ground. In large part, the conservation argument for open space was a refashioning of the New Deal concept of watershed planning. As the New Dealers recognized, the way people used the land had direct effects on the hydrological system of a region. But the conservation argument also built on new scientific ideas. Open space was necessary to maintain "ecological balance"—that is, to preserve the complex community of living things that sustain human society (Niering 1960; McHarg 1964; Stegner 1965; Shomon 1971). At least until the late 1960s, the new ecological thinking was confined to a few professional circles. But the argument eventually became more popular and more influential.

The aesthetic argument was potent from the start. To many people, the housing tracts simply were ugly. They were places with no character. The 1950s saw a fierce in-

tellectual attack on mass culture, and the aesthetic critique of tract-house development was partly a highbrow response to a novel form of mass production. In the view of some critics, indeed, the postwar suburbs did not deserve the name, because they so manifestly lacked the parklike spaciousness of the suburbs built earlier for the wealthy. But the advocates of open space were proposing a solution to a specific problem, not simply deriding a general cultural phenomenon. To give life to new subdivisions, the critics argued, there had to be some open space. Open space provided visual relief from the monotony of sprawl (U.S. Congress, Senate 1961, 997). Open space also helped to define communities, to set one place off from another, and so gave residents a sense of belonging to a place (Architectural Forum 1958; Owen 1959).

But usually the aesthetic argument was more basic. People wanted and needed the chance to enjoy the beauty of nature. As one scientist wrote, "the average person wants more and more to conserve nature simply because it is there; because it is good to look at and be in" (Niering 1960, 53). Of course, that argument was not new in the 1950s. But the appreciation for nature in the 1950s certainly was more widespread than ever before. The dozens of best-selling books on nature, the popularity of television series about wild animals and wild places, the increasing strength of the movement to create a national system of wilderness areas—all made clear the growing appeal of natural beauty. For many Americans, in other words, it was increasingly important to have everyday opportunities to appreciate nature: The occasional weekend or vacation trip no longer was enough (Jarrett 1958; Herring 1961; U.S. Congress, House 1961; Wurster 1961).

The recreation profession took the aesthetic argument a step farther. People needed a range of recreational spaces, from structured playgrounds to natural areas, and the postwar suburbs were not meeting those needs. But the argument went deeper, because, in the minds of many Americans, recreation was tied up with a number of profound social issues. The 1950s were marked by a major campaign against juvenile delinquency, and advocates of recreational open space often claimed that access to nature would help to ensure the healthy social development of children. The unprecedented affluence of the postwar years also led to new concerns about the social consequences of increased leisure time (Tucker 1959; U.S. Congress, Senate 1961; Tupper 1966). In 1958, as a result, the U.S. Congress voted to fund a massive, multiyear study of the nation's outdoor recreation resources.

Often, the recreation issue was discussed in abstract statistical terms. The boom in population, a reduction in the industrial workweek, and intensified demands on existing parks and recreational facilities argued that the nation had to make a concerted effort to provide new recreational space. So recreational space became a resource, like trees or energy or water, which could be overexploited. Indeed, one of the first major studies of the issue was conducted by Resources for the Future, which also offered long-term analyses of the more conventional resources (Clawson 1958). But for many residents of suburbia, the recreation issue was much more tangible and personal.

In new subdivisions, children often were able to play in undeveloped land nearby. Then one day the bulldozers would come to turn those playgrounds into lots for new houses, and both parents and children often reacted with shock and outrage (Whyte 1959c; Bagdikian 1966; Tupper 1966). In 1962, for example, a seven-year-old boy from California made national news when he sought the help of President John F. Kennedy after discovering that development was destroying his favorite place to hunt for lizards: "Dear Mr President," he wrote, "we Have no Place to go when we want to go out in the canyon Because there are going to Build houses So could you setaside some land where we could Play? thank you four listening love scott" (Open Space Action Committee 1965, 8). In other cases, parents took action, joining together to try to save the woods or streams or hills so cherished by their children.

THE SEARCH FOR OPEN-SPACE SOLUTIONS

What could people do to save open space? For more than a decade, Whyte provided the most influential answers to that question, and a consideration of his work offers a concise way to understand the impact of the open-space campaigns of the 1950s and 1960s. An assistant managing editor at *Fortune*, Whyte was able to enlist the resources of a vast publishing empire to make his case for the preservation of open space. In 1957 he was one of two organizers of a roundtable discussion—published in *Fortune*'s sister publication, *Architectural Forum*—on "The City's Threat to Open Land" (Architectural Forum 1958). He contributed an essay on "Urban Sprawl" to a multipart *Fortune* series on "The Exploding Metropolis," which was republished as a book (1958c). In *Life*, he offered "A Plan to Save the Vanishing Countryside" (1959c). Whyte also made his case to members of a number of professional organizations, including the National Association of Home Builders, the American Society of Planning Officials, the Urban Land Institute, and the American Society of Landscape Architects (1958a, 1958b, 1959a, 1959b). When the U.S. Senate held a hearing on a bill to encourage open-space preservation, Whyte was the first witness to testify (U.S. Congress, Senate 1961, 1002–1010). A year later he wrote a report on open-space action for the federal commission on outdoor recreation (1962). Throughout the 1960s, indeed, he continued to publish influential work, culminating in his classic, *The Last Landscape* (1968).

In large part, Whyte was able to win audiences because he emphasized the possibilities for action. His was an appealing hope that Americans could solve the open-space problem without fundamentally changing the structure of the real estate market and without rethinking the rights and responsibilities of property ownership. As Whyte himself vouchsafed, his proposals were conservative (1958c, 154, 156).

Whyte rejected as impractical the dream of many urban planners—the creation of regional planning agencies with the power to reserve land as green space. The need for action was too urgent to wait for perfect planning solutions. Whyte also rejected the use of zoning. Although zoning had a role in preserving open space, zoning decisions were too easy to overturn. More importantly, the use of regulation to enforce open-space preservation was unfair and probably unconstitutional. What could justify restrictions on the right of landowners to develop their property? The

regulatory powers of a community should be used only to prevent property owners from doing tangible harm, Whyte argued, not to compel them to provide a community benefit. If a community wanted to enjoy open space, the taxpayers might as well expect to pay for the privilege. In many cases, communities simply should acquire desirable lands as swiftly as possible. But Whyte also argued for the use of conservation easements. If citizens wanted a landowner to preserve a meadow or a marsh, they could buy the right to develop the property—and never exercise that right. The property owner then would be compensated for the loss of potential profit, and the community would have the benefits of open space without the financial burdens of ownership (1958c, 1959c).

In his 1959 article in *Life*, Whyte also argued for a second approach—what would soon be known as cluster or planned unit development—to preserve open space within subdivisions, not just between them. The nation's zoning laws should be revised to allow subdivisions that made room for large communal tracts of open space by clustering homes on smaller-than-standard lots. The developers would gain with such a layout because they would have to spend less per home on streets, land clearing, and utility hookups. The residents also would benefit—by giving up a bit of their yards they could enjoy a meadow, a hilly woodland, or a creek. Indeed, the cluster layout would turn potential annoyances into amenities. If a stream gully runs through a subdivision, Whyte explained, “it will not be chopped up into a patch of back lots that will only be a headache for the owners to keep up. Instead it will be left as a whole so that all the residents can use it. The density of the development will be the same as under the conventional pattern, but a lot more *space* will be created—and at less cost to the community, to the developer, and to the residents themselves” (1959c, 94).

In the early 1960s Whyte became even more convinced that builders needed to abandon “the land-wasting pattern” of subdivision design. He included a section on innovative site planning in his report to the outdoor recreation commission, and he made a study of cluster developments with help from the Rockefeller Brothers Foundation (1962, 1964). He also devoted a chapter of *The Last Landscape* to cluster design. In his view, the point was inescapable: “People have to live somewhere, as it is often said, and if there is to be any hope of having open space in the future, there is going to have to be a more efficient pattern of building” (1968, 199).

Of course, public debate about the best solutions to the open-space problem was not limited to the approaches championed by Whyte. By 1960, for example, a number of liberal Democrats were pushing for a federal program to help local governments acquire large “banks” of land at the frontiers of metropolitan settlement (Wurster 1960; Scott 1969; Gelfand 1975). In addition to preserving open space, the land banks would allow citizens to exercise more control over the timing and location of development, because public officials could sell or hold the fringe properties in accordance with public plans. The Kennedy administration initially endorsed the land-banking idea, but the real estate and homebuilding industries blasted the proposal as a dangerous, untested meddling with the market, and the idea went nowhere.

In contrast, Whyte's proposals won significant support. In his home state of New York, the legislature in 1960 created a \$75 million program to help local governments acquire open space. By 1965 six more states, including California, had offered grants to local governments for open-space acquisition. Several other states had begun ambitious programs to acquire land for outdoor recreation—often land that doubled as open space. Across the nation, local spending for park acquisition rose sharply in the early 1960s. The number of cities and counties with nature trails almost tripled from 1960 to 1965. A few local governments even acquired land solely to create greenbelts (Rome 1996).

The federal government began to support open-space preservation. Although the land-bank proposal was killed, a pioneering program to help city and county governments acquire open space was included in the Housing Act of 1961, despite opposition from fiscal conservatives in both parties (Foss 1971). Federal aid for open-space acquisition increased significantly in the mid-1960s, when President Lyndon B. Johnson made a campaign for "natural beauty" a key part of the Great Society environmental agenda (Melosi 1987).

By the early 1960s the cluster-development idea had gained considerable momentum. The American Society of Planning Officials issued a report promoting cluster subdivisions (Rosenthal 1960). The administrator of the federal Housing and Home Finance Agency endorsed the idea, and the agency revised its minimum standards to allow open-space developments (FHA 1963). Perhaps most important, the spokespeople for the nation's self-consciously progressive builders began to voice support for new subdivision layouts. The Urban Land Institute and the National Association of Home Builders encouraged cluster design in a number of publications, including a market study, and the trade press of the industry soon was filled with articles on the need for smarter land-use planning (Norcross 1966). The cluster concept also won laurels from commentators in a range of mass-circulation periodicals, from the *New York Times Magazine* to *Sports Illustrated* (Boyle 1964; Huxtable 1964). Despite a number of significant successes, however, the twofold strategy advocated by Whyte proved inadequate.

The acquisition effort was outpaced by development. As a number of officials acknowledged by the late 1960s, taxpayers in most cities and states were not able or willing to provide the funds to ensure adequate open space in rapidly expanding metropolitan areas. The cost of land kept rising, and the competition for public funds was keen, because many fast-growing areas also faced difficulties paying for such essential community facilities as sewers and schools. In 1974, for example, a study of the open-space issue in California concluded simply: "The impossibility of acquiring in fee the land area necessary for open space purposes has now become obvious" (Smith and Riggs 1974, 143).

Despite the chorus of praise for the cluster concept in the early 1960s, the effort to transform the design of subdivisions failed even more obviously to live up to the hopes of open-space advocates. Cities and towns often were reluctant to change their zoning rules because of the fear that clustering would lead to cheap, crowded

developments with “undesirable” residents. But even where developers were free to employ new site-planning concepts, the results were disappointing. Few cluster developments used the resources of terrain—hills, streams, woods, wetlands—to provide satisfying grounds. Often, in fact, the only “open spaces” were pools, tennis courts, and routinely landscaped clubhouses. As Whyte acknowledged, the site plan in cluster developments was generally a “hack” job, commonly designed not by a landscape architect but by a surveyor or an engineer: The real purpose was to squeeze the maximum number of units out of the land (1964, 14; 1968, 212).

Whyte still believed that the potential of clustering could be realized if public officials showed more care and imagination in reviewing site plans. By 1970, however, the momentum had shifted toward a far greater reliance on regulatory powers than Whyte thought wise. As the ecological point of view became more widespread, cities and counties turned increasingly to regulation to protect wetlands, streams, hillsides, and floodplains. More and more, both grassroots activists and government officials also saw the difficulty of acquiring open space as part of a larger problem: uncontrolled growth. The high cost of land was due partly to the speculation inherent in sprawl, while the competition for public funds was made more acute by the high cost of infrastructure in “spread city.” Accordingly, cities and counties began to do more to try to control development and to force developers to pay a larger share of the public costs of growth (Scott 1975; Kusler 1980).

In part, then, the failure of Whyte’s proposals was tied to a kind of paradigm shift. Whyte always believed that the strongest argument for open space was aesthetic. Even in 1968, when the science of ecology had begun to shape the thinking of millions of Americans, Whyte downplayed the conservationist arguments for open-space preservation. But he underestimated the power of the ecological idea that everything is connected. If the destruction of open space threatened the health of vital natural systems, then the issue no longer could be described in Whyte’s terms. It was not a matter of how best to secure a benefit; rather, it was a question of preventing a long-term disaster. According to a number of advocates, indeed, the preservation of open space was essential for survival (Little and Mitchell 1971, ix, 1–6; Shomon 1971, x).

But there was a more fundamental problem with Whyte’s conservative approach. Even though the loss of open space was a direct consequence of the ways in which postwar builders did business, Whyte was unwilling to challenge the basic premises of the industry. His argument for open-space acquisition failed to touch the building industry at all: He simply called on citizens to act with foresight to promote the public good. Even his argument for cluster development was directed as much at public officials and homebuyers as at builders. He urged cities and counties to give subdivision developers freedom from restrictive standards about lot size, minimum setbacks, and density in return for the inclusion of open space. He described for homebuyers the satisfactions of a cluster home. In both, he was often successful. But Whyte’s pitch to builders—a dollars-and-cents appeal to self-interest—fell flat. Although he demonstrated that cluster developments could be profitable, a majority of builders evidently concluded that conventional site planning offered more profit

with less trouble. No doubt, they were right. As the conservationist Aldo Leopold argued in a different context, “a system of conservation based solely on economic self-interest is hopelessly lopsided” (1949, 214).

By the early 1970s, therefore, even a number of Republican leaders were arguing in very unWhytian terms for a rethinking of the rights and responsibilities of property ownership. The new tenor of the debate is well illustrated by a 1973 report entitled *The Use of Land: A Citizens' Policy Guide to Urban Growth*. Although it was the work of a task force that included Pete Wilson, then mayor of San Diego, and William Reilly, a conservationist later appointed by President George H. W. Bush to head the Environmental Protection Agency, the report called for a new understanding of land. “It is time to change the view that land is little more than a commodity to be exploited and traded,” the report declared. “We need a land ethic that regards land as a resource which, improperly used, can have the same ill-effects as the pollution of air and water, and which therefore warrants similar protection” (Reilly 1973, 7).

Accordingly, the report argued for a dramatic expansion of public efforts to regulate private property. The argument rested on a matter-of-fact acknowledgment of the limitations of the profit motive as a tool of conservation: “Of course, in a market-based economic system, profitability and the public interest can and do diverge,” the report noted. “Thus, it makes sense for governments to prevent conditions in which owners (or builders or lenders) have the opportunity to obtain greater profit by acting contrary to the public interest” (Reilly 1973, 222).

To make sure that readers caught the implications of that point, the report also rejected outright the major legal and philosophical obstacles to regulation, especially the understanding of property rights embodied in the “takings” concept. Property owners did not have an absolute right to use their land as they saw fit. The report called for a campaign to overcome the common view that a restriction of the opportunity to develop land in effect robbed property owners of a rightful part of the value of their property: “Land whose development would be hazardous may be the place to begin. Surely it should be possible to develop a national consensus that profits from the residential development of a floodway are the moral equivalent of profits from selling tainted meat. Beyond this, though more slowly, it should be possible to develop an equivalent consensus with respect to land where development would damage valuable and irreplaceable resources or significantly interfere with natural processes” (Reilly 1973, 124). Eventually, then, the consensus would encompass a variety of lands, including “important open spaces.”

To be sure, the consensus envisioned by the authors of *The Use of Land* proved difficult to achieve. But the report makes clear how much had changed in a little more than a decade, from the late 1950s to the early 1970s. At first a majority of open-space advocates shared Whyte's hope that the postwar pattern of development could be improved without reforming the process of homebuilding. But the experience of the 1960s failed to sustain that hope. Although Whyte's proposals won considerable support, the destruction of open space continued and even accelerated. As a result, the argument for regulation became more compelling.

OPEN SPACE AND THE ENVIRONMENTAL MOVEMENT

The most direct legacy of the campaign to save open space was increased support for land-use regulation, but the effort also affected the emerging environmental movement. The open-space issue pointed conservationists toward a broader, more "environmental" agenda. It created a new group of activists and a new set of grassroots organizations. Perhaps most significantly, the open-space issue contributed to the development of a distinctly environmentalist rhetoric and imagery.

Throughout the 1960s the authors of environmentalist manifestos pointed to suburban sprawl as a critical problem. "Our cities have grown too fast to grow well, and today they are a focal point of the quiet crisis in conservation," Secretary of the Interior Stewart Udall wrote in his 1963 history of the conservation movement. "We must act decisively—and soon—if we are to assert the people's right to clean air and water, to open space, to well-designed urban areas, to mental and physical health" (Udall 1963, 159–160, 172). Two years later Raymond Dasmann blamed the postwar pattern of development for much of "the destruction of California":

Already we have filled the San Francisco Bay basin with housing, industry, airfields, and highways, from the tops of the hills to the edge of the water. The same thing has happened to Los Angeles. In the Central Valley, from the head in the sloughs leading to San Francisco Bay as far east as the Sierra foothills, one housing tract replaces another in a formless mass of suburbs that have been aptly termed "slurbs." If it could end at this it would be bad enough, but reparable. Instead, the process goes on. Housing and industry spread ever farther, engulfing farm and forest, marsh and pasture with no end in sight except the dismal one of a gigantic, disorganized megalopolis, filling much of the state and depending for its food on distant lands. (1965, 19)

Similarly, Robert Rienow and Leona Train Rienow devoted a chapter to the problem of "space and sprawl" in a best-selling 1967 manifesto on "the deteriorating quality of the American environment" (1967, 43–53).

For Lyndon Johnson, the first postwar president to make environmental issues a top priority, the loss of open space to suburban development was one of the principal justifications for a new federal role in protecting the environment. The structure of Johnson's 1965 address on conservation and restoration of natural beauty made that clear. In a list of modern forces that threatened the nation's natural heritage, Johnson put urbanization first. "Cities themselves reach out into the countryside, destroying streams and trees and meadows as they go," he explained. Then he cited the damage done by pollution, the "darker side" of modern technology. "To deal with these new problems will require a new conservation," he argued. "We must not only protect the countryside and save it from destruction, we must restore what has been destroyed and salvage the beauty and charm of our cities" (Foss 1971, 661).

The open-space issue thus helps to answer the most basic question about the rise of environmentalism: Why did the movement become a force in the decades after World War II? The history of the issue also helps to explain the evolution of an explicitly environmentalist agenda.

By the end of the 1950s the spread of the suburbs had led a number of conservationists to widen their field of view and action. One of the first signs of change came in a 1958 volume entitled *Perspectives on Conservation*, which included a section on "Urban Growth and Natural Resources" (Jarrett 1958, 115–154). The main contribution to the section argued that the postwar pattern of settlement greatly intensified the pressures on the nation's vital resources. It filled valuable open space, destroyed prime agricultural lands, increased flood hazards, spread air and water pollution, increased the use of energy for transportation, and threatened water shortages. Accordingly, the nation's conservationists had to begin to think along new lines.

The new thinking did not come easily. In congressional hearings on the open-space provisions of the Housing Act of 1961, only four conservation organizations submitted evidence. The sole conservation official to appear at the Senate hearing was Spencer Smith of the Citizens Committee on Natural Resources, a coalition of conservation groups that had formed during the fight to save Dinosaur National Monument. Still, Smith's testimony was significant. He began by assuring the senators that almost all of the national conservation organizations were "very much in favor" of the effort to preserve open space.

Smith then attacked head-on the traditional view of the scope of conservation. Although people generally assumed that conservation was concerned with the wise use of agricultural and public lands, Smith testified, that was wrong: "Actually conservation is of supreme importance within the cities too" (U.S. Congress, Senate 1961, 1015). To support that point, Smith cited the major arguments for open-space preservation. Open space was vital in providing adequate opportunities for recreation—and meeting the need for the sort of refreshment that natural beauty provided. Open space was also vital as a tool in dealing with the problems of water supply and water management, because it was a check against soil erosion and flooding.

The National Audubon Society provided the best evidence that Smith truly spoke for the major conservation organizations. The society's president in the late 1950s, John Baker, was a leader of a task force that conducted an influential campaign for open-space acquisition in the New York Metropolitan Area. Baker's successor, Carl Buchheister, endorsed the campaign in one of his monthly reports to the membership in *Audubon Magazine*. His assistant also submitted a brief in favor of the open-space provisions of the Housing Act of 1961. "As the Nation's oldest citizen's organization concerned with the conservation of nature and wildlife," the brief explained, "we have been increasingly concerned with the importance—indeed, the dire necessity—of adequate planning and timely action to preserve open spaces and natural beauty in urban and suburban areas" (U.S. Congress, House 1961, 863).

For the Audubon Society, indeed, the open-space issue was a bridge between old and new missions in the early 1960s. As president, Buchheister wanted to take a more activist role in a wider range of issues, and the campaign to preserve open space was a way to move in that direction without breaking fundamentally with the traditions of the organization. The society had long maintained wildlife sanctuaries around the country and was just beginning to establish nature centers to educate children and

adults. Because both activities involved preservation of land, the jump to open-space activism was easy. The land for the society's most celebrated nature center, Aullwood, was a gift from a woman who was concerned about the loss of open space around Dayton, Ohio, in the decade after World War II (Rome 1996). But the open-space issue pointed Audubon members in new directions, too, because the arguments for urban green space ultimately drew on new ecological principles. According to a 1971 Audubon guidebook, *Open Land for Urban America*, Americans needed to see the city anew as a complex organism. The guide therefore included a long chapter on the function of open space in maintaining the carbon and hydrological cycles, reducing the effects of water and air pollution, and moderating the extremes of urban climate (Shomon 1971, 21–40).

In addition to nudging a few old-line conservation organizations in new directions, the open-space issue nurtured the sort of grassroots activism that became the heart of the environmental movement after 1970. Across the nation, people formed new organizations to preserve patches of green in fast-growing cities and suburbs. Californians joined People for Open Space, St. Louis had the Open Space Council, and New Yorkers formed the Open Space Action Institute (Degan 1965; Little and Mitchell 1971; Shomon 1971; Smith and Riggs 1974). Throughout the 1960s activists published guides to community organizing to save open space (Hubbard 1960; Little and Mitchell 1971; Platt 1971; Reilly 1973). In one short guide, published in the *National Civic Review* and reprinted in *Reader's Digest*, the author began by telling of one woman's successful campaign to preserve a marsh from development. "The war Ruth Rusch has been waging in her little corner of suburbia contains immense significance for all of us," he wrote. "For it shows not only that we can win the fight to save our landscape from the despoilers, but also specifically how to go about it" (Miller 1964, 355).

Well before 1970, therefore, the destruction of open space had led many middle-class Americans to reassess the costs and benefits of economic growth. The millions of new homes in the suburbs were the most striking symbols of the blessings brought by the postwar boom; and yet, as Whyte warned in 1957, "much more of this kind of progress and we shall have the paradox of prosperity lowering our real standard of living" (1958c, 133). By the early 1960s the advocates of open-space preservation often set the word "progress" in quotation marks to express their intensifying doubts. For many activists, the doubts about the postwar pattern of development eventually led to anger, often expressed in a recognizably environmentalist rhetoric of destruction, murder, and despoliation. "If this 'progress' were true progress," one wrote, "no one would have cause for complaint. But, in fact, 'progress' has come to stand for stupidity, greed, graft, malice, and moral debasement. We have imperiled the charms of our cities; now the countryside is being laid waste" (Boyle 1964, 80).

Occasionally, the rhetoric of open-space advocacy was even more intimate. In a hearing on the open-space provision of the Housing Act of 1961, the executive director of the American Society of Landscape Architects tentatively spoke of the destruction of the countryside as a "rape" (U.S. Congress, Senate 1961, 606). By the

mid-1960s the word had become common in public debate about the fate of open space, as articles and book chapters decried “the rape of the land” (Whyte 1959c, 90; Bagdikian 1966; Tupper 1966, 17–37).

The new emotional tone is especially evident in a passage from Margo Tupper’s *No Place to Play*. Like millions of Americans, Tupper moved with her family to the suburbs after World War II:

At that time our house was second from the last on a dead-end street. Beyond were acres of untouched woodlands which were a refuge for children—a place to play in natural surroundings. Youngsters in the neighborhood would go there, build dams or catch minnows in a little creek, gather wildflowers and pick blossoms from the white dogwoods. They built tree houses, picnicked under the tall tulip trees, and dug jack-in-the-pulpits, wild fern and violets to transplant to their gardens. . . .

Then one day my little girl, Jan, ran into the house shouting, “Mother, there’s a bulldozer up the street. The men say they’re going to cut down the trees. They can’t do that. They’re *my* trees! Where will we play? Please, mother, please stop them.” Jan ran frantically out the door, shouting, “I’ll get Susan, Georgie, Sissy and all the other children. If they’re going to take our woods away we’ll have to save all we can.” The children returned several hours later pulling wagons loaded with flowers and plants. Jan brought home a small dogwood tree and planted it among the wildflowers in the south garden. . . .

Indeed the bulldozers did come! These huge earth-eating machines raped the woods, filled up the creek, buried the wildflowers and frightened away the rabbits and the birds. The power saws came too and took part in the murder of the woodlands near our home. Dynamite blasted out the huge tree roots; trucks roared past our house carrying the remains, sections of murdered trees and tons of earth in which were buried vines, shrubs, and flowers. Then the dozers came to level the earth and power shovels to dig great holes. In less than a month the first of two hundred look-alike, closely-set small houses rose to take the place of our beautiful forest. (1966, 18–19)

Of course, Tupper’s outraged language owed much to the rhetoric of earlier preservation campaigns—for John Muir, to cite a famous example, the proponents of the Hetch Hetchy dam were “temple destroyers”—but the charge of rape also pointed in a new direction. The ravagers were not far away, building a massive structure in a valley of sacred beauty; they were next door, doing everyday work, and they threatened the well-being of families at home.

As Tupper’s account suggests, the destruction of open space also provided a powerful new symbol of technology run amok. “To the right-thinking suburbanite,” the landscape critic J. B. Jackson wrote in 1966, “the bulldozer is the very embodiment of ruthless destruction” (1977, 33). Jackson did not share that view, but he clearly was in the minority among commentators on the new metropolitan landscape. By the mid-1960s the literature on suburbia was full of attacks on “the age of the bulldozer,” “the bulldozer blitz,” and “the bulldozer mentality” (Lord 1962, 343, 347; Degnan 1965, 242, 245; Darling and Milton 1966, 318, 329). To a number of observers, the bulldozed landscape brought to mind the desolation of a battlefield.

Again and again the critics tallied the losses. "The bulldozerite . . . tears down in one swoop what nature has caused to grow over the ages," a dismayed architect wrote. "Trees and bushes, meadows and flowers, brooks and rivers are torn out or leveled, and the operation is admired as a triumph of technology" (Gruen 1964, 102–103).

Often, the attacks on the bulldozer were supported by stark aerial photographs of the construction of subdivisions. In one famous series of photographs, reproduced in Peter Blake's polemic *God's Own Junkyard: The Planned Deterioration of America's Landscape*, the first image simply was a vast expanse of dirt, crisscrossed by bulldozer tracks, with no topographical features, no vegetation—indeed, no visible life of any kind (1964, 106–107). The image of bulldozers tearing down hills appeared repeatedly in the work of open-space activists (Tucker 1959; Whyte 1959c; Gruen 1964). The moral was clear: The bulldozer was a tool of arrogance, a symbol of the nation's devastating disregard for nature.

By the late 1960s, therefore, the effort to preserve open space and the environmental movement had become intertwined in complex ways. The emergence of a popular ecological consciousness strengthened the conservation argument for open space. At the same time, the campaign for open space increased the range of support for the environmentalist cause. Indeed, the image of the bulldozer in the countryside became a shorthand for one of the basic dichotomies in environmentalist argument, a dichotomy now almost a cliché: the opposition of prodevelopment and proenvironment.

At first, to be sure, few activists defined the open-space issue in such oppositional terms. In the late 1950s the can-do optimism of William Whyte was still common. Although convinced that action was needed at once, Whyte never suggested that the issue called into question any fundamental aspect of American society. Instead, he argued that the nation could save enough open space if good people would just get to it. But the problem proved to be less tractable than Whyte assumed. When the campaigns for land acquisition and cluster development came up short, many open-space advocates began to think more deeply about the sources of the problem. For some, the rethinking led to calls for a redefinition of the rights of property ownership. For others, the result was a new sense of the environmental irresponsibility of American culture.

NOTE

1. Samuel P. Hays is one of the few scholars of environmentalism to have considered the importance of the open-space issue. In his major work on the environmental movement, he devotes four pages to strategies for open-space preservation and concludes: "The urban fringe continued to be a major battleground in the conflict between environmental and developmental objectives. Out of this experience came many ideas about environmental quality, support for environmental organizations, and political action" (1987, 95). I discuss the open-space campaigns at length in my dissertation (Rome 1996), and additional documentation for my argument can be found there.

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